

A Dog Is...

Before we teach a single trick, a single cue, or a single step of choreography, let's first stop to ask THE question most people skip entirely.

What actually is a dog?

Not "what is a Border Collie" or "what is my breed good at." Not even "what is my dog's personality." Something more basic than that...

What is a dog?

Respect the dog's senses and instincts before you demand self-control



A lot of frustration in dog training comes from expecting a dog to value what we value. You want calm, focus, and self-control. But your dog defaults to smell first, then movement, then novelty. On a walk, you see a route. Your dog experiences a world full of information that you can't even detect. If you demand self-control without understanding that first, you're asking for too much, too soon.

They live in our world, trying to make sense of a species that doesn't move, smell, or think the way they do.

They're like someone dropped into a foreign country when they never asked for it, with no map, no dictionary, and no way to ask for directions. And only has you to guide them... in a language they don't understand.

Chewing, pulling, barking, scanning - these aren't defiance. They're normal dog strategies. Chewing regulates stress. Pulling means your dog wants to investigate faster than you're moving. Barking is communication. Scanning means the environment feels unpredictable and they're gathering information. Before you label something 'bad,' ask yourself: what is my dog actually trying to do right now?"

So instead of trying to suppress the natural behaviors that don't fit your lifestyle, let's think about how we can use them. Every natural instinct your dog has can be redirected into something that strengthens the bond or builds a solid behavior. If they need to sniff, build sniff time into your routine as a reward for attention, or teach them to use their nose in a searching game. If movement is what drives them, use that energy to build engagement. If they want to chew and use their mouth, channel it into a solid tug game with you.

You're not letting them 'get away with it.' You're just finally working with them, instead of against them.

Responsibility is the key

When we take a dog into our life, we do it with a promise: to give them the best life possible.

It is our responsibility to keep that promise; to be their translator, their guide and the one who makes sense of a world they don't yet understand. They didn't sign up to learn our rules. We're the ones who signed up to teach them, and it's our responsibility to do it fairly, patiently and in a way they can truly enjoy it.

So when they get something wrong, your first question shouldn't be "what's wrong with them?" but rather, "how can I explain myself better, so that they could understand?"

If the dog is pulling, barking, freezing, or ignoring you, treat it as information: the cue was unclear, the step was too big, the environment was too hard, or the dog's needs were unmet.

Build a bond that makes learning possible

Training works best when it stops being a checklist of tricks and becomes communication. You are not “installing” behaviors into a dog. You are building a shared language, then using it to cooperate in real life. When something fails, it is rarely because your dog is being stubborn. More often, the message was unclear, the situation was too hard, or the relationship account was overdrawn that day.

Think of trust, engagement, and clarity as daily skills you practice, not personality traits your dog either has or lacks. Trust grows when your dog can predict you. You follow through calmly, you keep promises, and you protect them from being pushed past their limits. Engagement grows when being with you consistently leads to something good: access to sniffing, play, food, movement, or relief. Clarity grows when your signals stay the same. Your timing improves. You reward what you want. You pause before repeating yourself and ask, “Did I make this easy to understand?”

The dog in front of you is capable of more than you think

They can learn to read your body before you finish moving and anticipate what's going to come. They can learn an entire language of small signals between the two of you.

The end vision is simple: partner-based teamwork. Your dog checks in because it pays off and because you have a history of being worth listening to, not because they are afraid of what happens if they don't. In that kind of partnership, you can ask for more self-control with less conflict, and you can handle mistakes without turning them into a power struggle.

That's what this course is about. Not tricks yet, but the Bond behind it all.

